Breakfast Mama

***Happiness delivery:** A primary school teacher at a tribal school in Kerala takes steps to make sure her wards are not sitting in class hungry*

By **JEEMON JACOB**

ASHISH K VINCENT



LINCY GEORGE, 42 TEACHER
Idukki, Kerala

Some three months ago, two Class IV students at the Government Tribal School in Murikattukudy in Kerala's hill district Idukki fainted during morning class. An inquiry revealed that the children had come to school hungry, without having breakfast. Shockingly, when the school did a headcount, some 120 students reluctantly admitted that they too were sitting in class hungry.

Lincy George, a partially blind primary school teacher, had taken the lead in the inquiry. She was horrified when 12 of her wards admitted that they had been coming to school on an empty stomach every day. The parents of many of the students worked at the nearby plantations, and left home early for work. "I shared my concerns with the other teachers and headmaster," says Lincy, "and we conducted a survey. It revealed that 120 of the 407 students were in the same situation. It pained me as a mother and as a teacher."

She discussed the issue with her husband Sebastian George, part of the clerical staff at a local school, and they decided to make arrangements for breakfast for the hungry students. Lincy raised funds from her own personal savings, colleagues and PTA officials and started her breakfast project some two months back. Many other people have also come forward now to sponsor the effort. Government and state-aided schools in Kerala already have a mid-day meal scheme in place for poor children, but "no school till now was providing breakfast for students", says Lincy. The programme has seen tremendous success; the students are more cheerful now and also actively participate in classroom activities. Lincy's efforts haven't stopped there. She has also helped build six houses for her wards who were living in sheds. ■

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"I get so much happiness in the company of my students, so it's my duty to make their life a little better. Every little bit counts...I feel like I have a big family to feed"

— LINCY GEORGE, Teacher

INDIA TODAY RPG Happiness Quest



ART AND SOUL

***Happiness delivery:** Reviving traditional handicrafts such as the Kani shawl by introducing new designs and patterns, inspiring the younger generation to learn the craft of their forefathers and using art to dispel stereotypes about Kashmir*

By **MOAZUM MOHAMMAD**